

Median unit rent (per week)

Sydney \$545
Melbourne \$400
Brisbane \$370
Adelaide \$295
Perth \$300
Hobart \$340
Darwin \$415
Canberra \$430

Source: Domain Group data for the December quarter, 2017

House-sitters' club

The young Australian rite of passage – backpacking through Europe – might be as much of a nomadic lifestyle as most can tolerate. But forfeiting a fixed address is an increasingly popular way to eventually step into a place of your own. House-sitting, rent-free, could be just the ticket if moving back in with your folks is not an option while you save.

House-sitting is a means to save enormous wads of your income while enjoying the spoils of a house you probably otherwise couldn't afford. Lots of owners looking for a house-sitter also have pets that need care and companionship while they're away; if you're an animal-lover who has been renting a property that doesn't allow pets, house-sitting is a way to be frugal and get your fur-baby fix.

The requests from homeowners, on bona-fide websites that assist with the transaction, are often basic: water the plants, mow the lawn, keep the property secure, and forward mail or phone messages, in exchange for free rent, often with utilities and Netflix thrown in.

Psychologist Katrina Parker, who is in her late 20s, has estimated that she and her partner are saving about 80 per cent of their incomes by house-sitting, which has put them on track to accumulating a home deposit in two years. In an interview with *Domain*, Parker said:

As well as saving money, [we are] able to try out and explore different suburbs to get an idea of where we'd like to have our own home.